Lesser-known Destinations

Beyond the big and popular destinations, there are many places in Rajasthan that are equally interesting but are lesser known.

Banswara

Named for 'bans' or bamboo, Banswara is tribal territory. Once the former Banswara state, it is bounded by Udaipur and Chittorgarh. An ancient town with stone walls, its City Palace is in the old Rajput style. The Anand Sagar Lake or Bai Talab is an artificial lake on the town's eastern side. There are beautiful chhatris here.

Baran

Part of Kota district until the early 1990s, Baran later became an independent district. Kakoni, 85 kilometres from Baran, lies on the banks of the Parwan River. The Kakoni temples were built in 8th century and some remains can be seen. The Bhand Devra temples in Ramgarh are 40 kilometres from Baran. The 10th-century Shiv Mandir of Ramgarh is based on the Khajuraho style and is known as Rajasthan's mini-Khajuraho.

Barmer

Barmer has a tough terrain and was once on the ancient camel trade route. Now it is a centre of various arts and crafts. Especially noteworthy are its geometric Ajrak prints. Barmer Fort is in ruins but has an interesting temple dedicated to Balark (the Sun). Kiradu has ruins of ancient temples. The 12th-century village of Meva Nagar, once called Viranipur, has three Jain temples.

Dungarpur

Nestled in the Aravalis, Dungarpur is noted for its unique architecture. The magnificent palaces and houses of nobility have lovely stone jharokhas. Udai Bilas Palace, the royal residence, is a fine example. Juna Mahal is a 13th-century seven-storied structure resembling a fortress, its interiors filled with beautiful frescoes and miniature paintings.

Nagaur

Nagaur's magnificent fort stands testament to the great battles fought here. The dargah of Hamiduddin Chishti Faruqui Nagauri, one of the chief disciples of Khwaja Moinuddin, is located here. Nagaur is also the birthplace of Saint Poetess Meera Bai and Abul Fazal. In 2007, the fort underwent major renovations and is now replete with fountains and gardens. The Meera Bai Light & Sound Show at Merta is a mesmerizing experience.

Abhaneri

Chand Baori (stepwell) in Abhaneri village is one of the oldest attractions in Rajasthan. It was built by King Chanda of the Nikumbha Dynasty in the 9th century. One of the largest stepwells in the world, Chand Baori was built to conserve water and provide respite from the intense heat. It was a community gathering place for royals and subjects alike. Chand Baori is an architectural wonder with 3,500 perfectly symmetrical, narrow steps.

Bhangarh

Nestled amid green hills, stands the magnificent fort of Bhangarh, 50 kilometres from the Sariska Sanctuary between Jaipur and Alwar. Now looked after by the ASI, the fort was constructed in the 17th century. Besides the royal palace, Bhangarh had over 9,000 houses until 1720 after which it gradually diminished in size. The fort houses remnants of grand havelis, temples and deserted marketplaces. It's thought to be haunted, and attracts many curious tourists.

Rajasthan became the first state in India to launch night sky astro-tourism in all its 33 districts. The capital itself, Jaipur, has four famous star-gazing venues including Jantar Mantar, Amber Fort, University Maharaja College and Jawahar Kala Kendra.



Deeg

Deeg is a beautiful garden town situated north of Bharatpur. It has many embellished palaces that add to its beauty. Known for its forts, palaces, gardens and fountains, the highlight of Deeg is an impressive fort surrounded by moats and gateways. It was built by Raja Suraj Mal and stands over a slightly elevated point.

Lodhurva

Located 15 kilometres from Jaisalmer, Lodhurva is the ancient capital of this region and was ruled by the Lodhi Parmars. With its magnificent Jain temples, it is an important pilgrimage spot. Originally constructed in the pre-12th century Maru-Gurjara style of the Chalukyas, the temples were reconstructed in a more ornate revivalist style in the 17th century.

Lohargal

Set in Jhunjhunu District, Lohargal is of mythological interest given its association with Bhima. There is a holy water tank here, where pilgrims come to wash away their sins. According to myth, the Pandava army bathed here after their glorious victory and found their weapons and armour melting away. Indeed, Lohargal is, literally, loha (iron) + gal (to melt). A large fair, held annually from Krishna Janmashtami to Amavasya, is a major draw.

Sundha Mata Temple

This nearly 900-year-old temple of the Goddess Chamunda is set on a hilltop in Rajasthan's Jalore District, 64 kilometres from Mount Abu. Made up of white marble, the temple's pillars are reminiscent of Abu's Dilwara temples. A beautiful idol of Goddess Chamunda stands under the huge stone.

